



BEFORE

The existence of social hierarchies often disadvantages vulnerable groups, such as the poor. The idea that everyone should have equal rights arose in the 18th century.

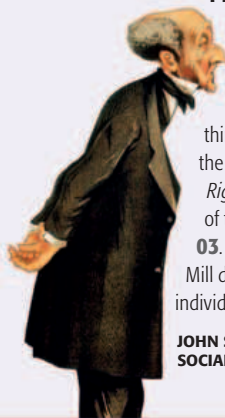
POLITICAL RIGHTS

The world's oldest written constitution for an independent state is the **US Constitution** of 1787 << 298–99, which set out the duties of government and its responsibilities toward its citizens. In 1789, the French Revolutionary Assembly issued the **Declaration of the Rights of Man** << 303. It stated that “all men are created equal” and defined various democratic principles, such as equality before the law and freedom from arbitrary arrest. Women, however, were excluded. In 1791 the US Bill of Rights guaranteed rights, such as **freedom of speech**, but it did not apply to blacks or American Indians.

PHILOSOPHICAL RIGHTS

Individual social reformers and philosophers were also important in the growth of human rights. The political thinker Tom Paine helped to draft the US Constitution and wrote *The Rights of Man* (1791–92) in support of the French Revolution << 302–03. English philosopher John Stuart Mill defended the freedom of the individual against state control.

JOHN STUART MILL, PROPONENT OF SOCIAL REFORM AND HUMAN RIGHTS



RIGHTS ACTIVIST (1884–1962)

ELEANOR ROOSEVELT

Eleanor Roosevelt, wife of President Franklin D. Roosevelt, is often called America's most significant First Lady. She was active in the League of Women Voters and the Women's Trade Union League. After the president's death, she was elected chair of the UN Human Rights Commission and played a key role in drafting the “Declaration of Universal Human Rights” (1948). She hoped it would be a “Magna Carta of all men everywhere,” the word “men” applying to both sexes.

